7.17 Dumbarton Rock, Scotland UK

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This case study describes a recent project that aimed to explore the significance of Dumbarton Rock, as a site of rock-climbing heritage, in terms of heritage and enabling community participation in the cultural heritage management system in Scotland. Dumbarton Rock comprises a number of heritage management legal designations, including one Scheduled Ancient Monument, a number of Listed Buildings, a geological Site of Special Scientific Interest and it is a significant location in the heritage of Scottish rock-climbing. This case study focusses on the 'living heritage' of an archaeological site, and how, as archaeological managers we can enable engaged communities to contribute to the management of these sites and so ensure that their heritage is taken into account as part of the conservation management of the place. This case study illustrates how Intangible Cultural Heritage can be place-based and why archaeological heritage management projects can enable community engagement, especially when it facilitates a better understanding of alternative and diverse heritages.

Context

Dumbarton Rock comprises a volcanic outcrop that stands on the north edge of the Firth of Clyde, 24km north-west of Glasgow city centre. The rock stands up to 73m tall but appears greater in height given the flat topography of the surrounding estuary (Fig.84). The following describes the context of the Rock and its early History:

'The twin peaks of Dumbarton Rock (a volcanic plug similar in origin to Edinburgh and Stirling Castle Hills) rise dramatically from the north shore of the Clyde at its confluence with the River Leven to form a site of great natural strength, which is reputed to have the longest recorded history of any fortification in Britain. From at least the 5th century AD it served as the principal stronghold of the Britons of Strathclyde, thereafter it was a royal castle, and during the postmedieval period the castle was used as an artillery fortress guarding the approaches to Glasgow.' (Stevenson 1985).

Figure 84: Dumbarton Rock in the Forth of Clyde. (Historic Environment Scotland)

As described above, the location and imposing geological form of the rock have been utilized by people over thousands of years and surviving archaeological remains cover the surface of the rock. These remains range in age from late Iron Age artefacts to the most recent military uses, which continued until 1909 when the responsibility for the rock was transferred from the War Office, to the Office of Works. The rock was used in World War Two, with four anti-aircraft guns positioned on the top. On the night of the 5th of May 1941, the rock was hit by four bombs. Since the war, the rock has functioned as an ex-military base, with occasional military events and in more recent years has become a major tourist attraction, managed by Historic Environment Scotland (HES).

'Statement of Significance' and cultural heritage management at HES sites in care

HES manages 336 properties, these range from castles, stone circles, industrial mills to archaeological landscapes, churches and Cold War installations, on behalf of Scottish Ministers and the people of Scotland. Each site is protected by legal designations, administered through specific place-based management plans and described in detail in a document known as a 'Statement of Significance'. As can be seen in the accompanying Statement of Significance for Dumbarton Castle, the format of the document for Dumbarton Castle follows acknowledged cultural heritage management protocols and is divided into the following sections:

- Synopsis
- Character of the Monument: comprising an historical timeline
- Archaeological Overview: details of excavations
- Architectural/Artistic Overview: historical details
- Social Overview: evidence of the significance of the site in the recent past, including 'the importance of the site for the climbing and bouldering community'
- Spiritual Overview: religious associations
- Aesthetic Overview: natural and topographical associations and connotations
- Assessment of Significance

The final section, 'Assessment of Significance', comprises a section of key points, which highlights what are considered to be the major characteristics that make the site of regional, national and international significance. It also includes 'Associated Properties', such as other sites in Scotland that are of similar age and significance, demonstrating a landscape networked with significant sites. The final part of the Dumbarton Castle Statement of Significance includes an appendix entitled 'Dumby: A contribution provided by Dumbarton Rock Climbers'.

The reasons why this case study can be of interest to heritage management practice more widely, are threefold:

- To develop new methodological, practice-based approaches to understanding significance
- To expand our conceptualisation of what archaeology can be and how archaeology is practiced at sites of 'alternative' heritages
- With a view to critiquing assumptions around expertise and knowledge sharing through engagement approaches

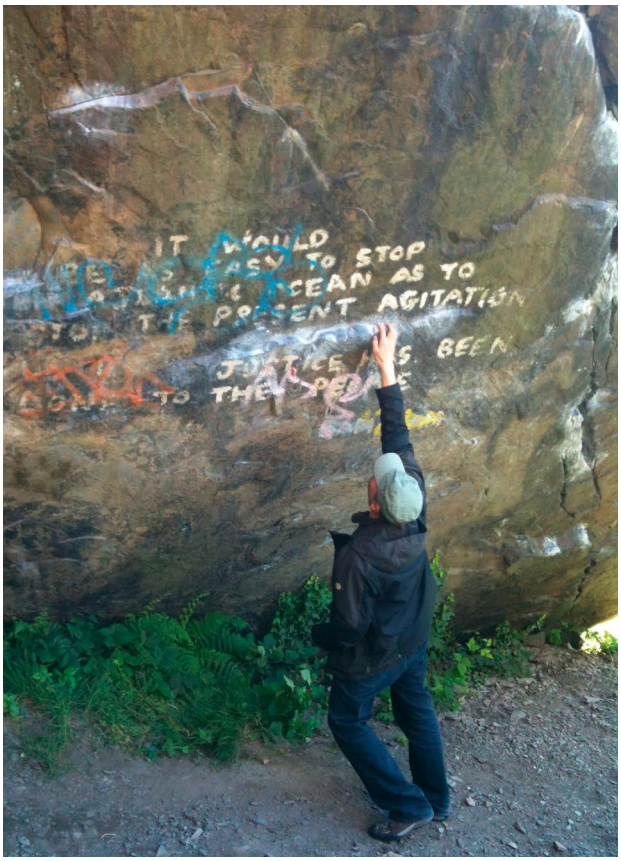

Figure 85: Graffiti and climbers chalk on the surface of the rock. (Historic Environment Scotland)

The Significance of Rock-Climbing at Dumby

Recently the climbing heritage at Dumbarton Rock, or 'Dumby' as it is known to the community of climbers, was one of ten sites across Scotland that were the focus of a research, partnership project called ACCORD (Archaeology Community Co-production of Research Data). The project aimed to enable communities to record heritage sites of their choice, using digital recording methods (Jeffrey et al, 2020). Most groups chose traditional archaeological sites and monuments, from a Bronze Age standing stone and an Iron Age roundhouse to World War Two memorials. Clearly, the site of Dumbarton Rock with its massive boulders and huge vertical wall of volcanic rock stand out from this group as 'untraditional' heritage. But as discovered during the project, the practice of climbing and bouldering has a long tradition, across Scotland and beyond. During the project it became clear that the site was significant because the climbers, present and past, had formed close physical and psychological connections with the materiality of the rock (Fig.85). Through the acts of climbing (and falling!), coming into close, sustained contact with the climbs, the holds, the problems and the physical presence of the rock, a sense of significance was established and that increased through further engagement with the place.

Dumby presents climbers with a concentration of boulders around the foot of the volcanic rock and an extensive vertical and in places over-hanging main crag, on the shoreline of the Firth of Clyde (see photo in the Canmore archive). The climbing route known as Rhapsody (E11 7a) on the main crag, was first ascended by Dave MacLeod in 2006 (Ryan, 2006). It is still considered one of the hardest traditional climbing routes in Scotland, and the first route in Britain with such a high level of difficulty (E11). This climb is one of the many reasons why the significance of climbing heritage at Dumbarton Rock provides an important case study for heritage management practice.

By collaborating with the climbing community, we were able to learn about a new form of heritage, apply archaeological recording methods (RTI survey and terrestrial laser scanning), with the climbers to record the boulders and topography of boulders and the climbing routes (Fig.86). In this way the project developed a knowledge sharing practice, recorded a new form of 'living' heritage, expanded the types of subjects that archaeology can engage with, to understand how people engage with the materiality of a part of Scotland. As a final part of the project, we worked with the climbers to enable them to incorporate their interpretation of the social significance of the site into the official Statement of Significance. This was the first time that community participants had been enabled to contribute to a Statement of Significance. In addition, the Statement is complimented by an academic paper that the project partners wrote collaboratively with the climbers. The paper outlines the methods applied and discusses the outputs, outcomes and the impacts that this form of co-production approach can have on significance and values, when alternative heritages are engaged with by archaeologists (Hale et al, 2017).

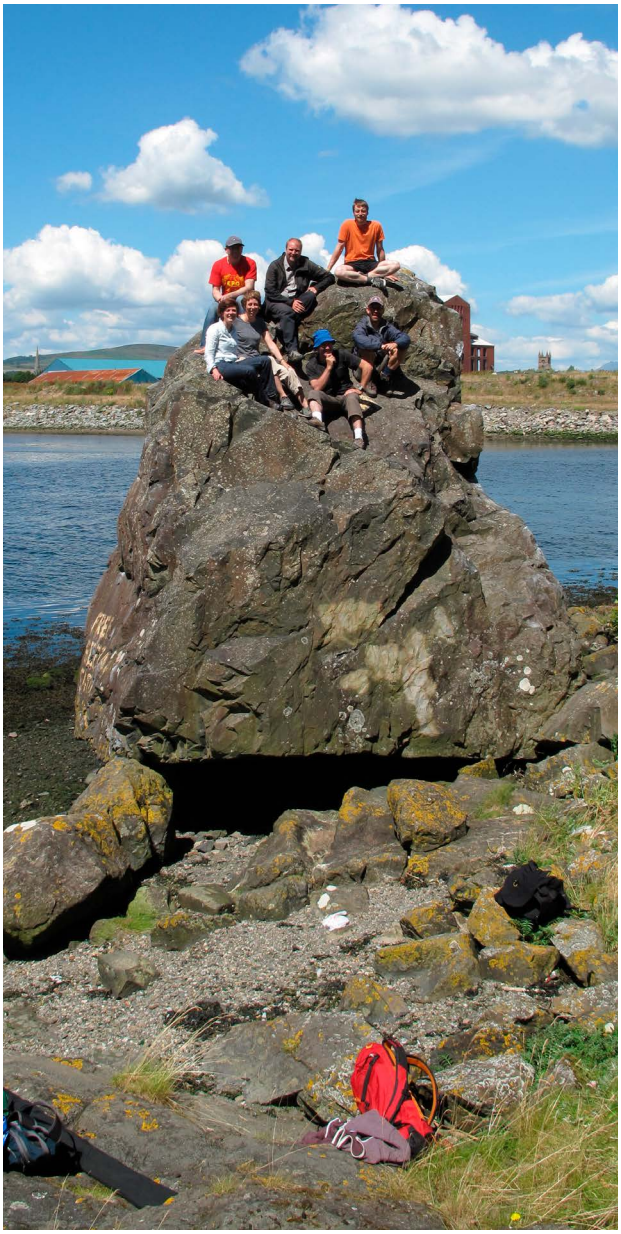

Figure 86: The project field team. (Historic Environment Scotland)